

A state of nature



Frontispiece of Hobbes's *Leviathan* with a quotation from the Book of Job, translated as 'There is no power on earth to be compared to him.'

As well as its flourishing culture, Renaissance Europe was marked by attempts to find a new political order to replace medieval feudalism. Independent states – republics as well as monarchies – emerged, and there was a renewed interest in how these should be governed. In England, the monarchy was overthrown in a civil war, but was restored after a short-lived republican Commonwealth as a 'constitutional monarchy', subject to the consent of Parliament. During this revolutionary period, Thomas Hobbes wrote *Leviathan*, an examination of the nature of society and government. No doubt influenced by the horrors of civil war, he argued that in what he called a 'state of nature', without political order, unlimited freedom allows

everyone to act in their own self-interest. Each person is pitted against others in a constant battle for survival, and life is 'solitary, poor, nasty, brutish and short'. The solution, he argued, is the formation of civil societies, in which people agree under a 'social contract' to subject themselves to the rule of a sovereign in return for security and prosperity.